

A Watched Pot Boiling

Street Protest and Public Opinion in Authoritarian Russia

Noah Buckley
Trinity College Dublin

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Protest in authoritarian regimes

- Autocrats' fear of popular protest is central to many theories of authoritarian survival (Simpser 2013; Svolik 2012)
- Informational and reputational cascade (Kuran 1991; Lohmann 1994)
 - Protest can lead to a spiral of yet more protest
- Monitoring of protest and sentiment
 - Informational autocracy (Guriev and Treisman 2020)
 - Autocrats put considerable effort into public opinion polls

What we know and what we don't

- Social desirability rather than fear of repression is behind much preference falsification (Buckley, Marquardt, Reuter, and Tertychnaya 2024)
- Protest works differently for different groups: state employees (Rosenfeld 2017), media consumption and regime response (Lankina and Tertychnaya 2019; Wasow 2020)
- Focus has been on the **social environment** and unexpected permission to protest (Frye and Borisova 2019)
- What about the **content of informational shocks** and their effects?
 - Real-world informational shocks can contain multiple 'messages' about society and regime
 - How do these diverse types of messages pull different levers?

Research questions

1. Does exposure to public protest shift **support** for a ruling authoritarian regime?
2. What are the **mechanisms** connecting exposure to protest and shifts in attitudes?

Theoretical framework: protest as informational shock

Observing public protest is an informational shock

- **[RQ1]** Potential effects on individuals:
 - Dislike of local regime **agents**
 - Disaffection with larger system, regime, **autocrat**
 - Willingness to take action yourself
- **[RQ2]** Content of informational shocks:
 1. Revelation about levels of social discontent
 2. Likelihood of repression by the regime
 3. Revelation about regime quality

Empirical strategy

- Very large database of public opinion data from Russia
 - Over 3.2 million responses, 2003–present
 - Interview date, subnational/geographical unit
- Scraped and coded data on protest events in Russia, 2007–2022
- Difference-in-differences approach to test hypotheses
- Individual-level survey data
- Treatment at the level of region
 - Proxy for observing protest
 - Future work: at the municipal level
- Rely on **precise timing of protest events** to identify this effect

Protest data



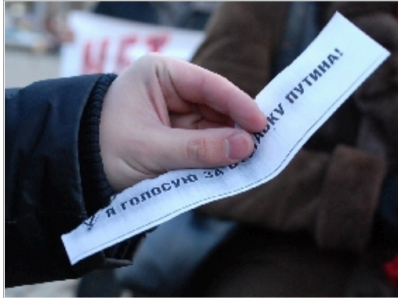
- Protest events web-scraped from namarsh.ru
 - Volunteer-run collective; cooperative effort of 3 opposition NGOs
 - The most complete and authoritative source on protest in Russia
 - Covers March 2007 to 2022
- Coded protest characteristics
 - a. Who is protesting
 - b. What are the demands, content
 - c. Number of protesters; detentions; approved by authorities
 - d. Location

Новости протеста

03.04.2009

К ответу!

В Твери прошел митинг за отставку Путина



В Твери 3 апреля прошел митинг объединенных оппозиционных сил. Акция была подготовлена и заявлена обкомом КПРФ. В нем приняли участие: ОГФ, РНДС, активисты тверского отделения "Яблока" и ДПНИ, сообщает корреспондент Каспаров.Ru.

Всего на Московской площади города Твери собрались около 1000 человек. Выступающие на митинге отметили, что уровень жизни в стране падает. Постоянно растут цены, а "представители власти живут в роскоши и покупают новые автомобили..."

"A demonstration calling for Putin's resignation took place in Tver" — 03.04.2009.

On April 3, a demonstration of the united opposition took place. The event was prepared and announced by the KPRF. ... In total, around 1000 people assembled... Attendees noted that the quality of life in the country is falling. Prices are rising while the authorities live in luxury...

Новости протеста

09.07.2017

На агитационных субботниках Навального по всей России задержано более 130 человек



Полиция задержала не менее 131 участников "агитационных субботников" в поддержку Алексея Навального, прошедших 8 июля в разных городах России, сообщает "ОВД-Инфо".

По информации агентства,

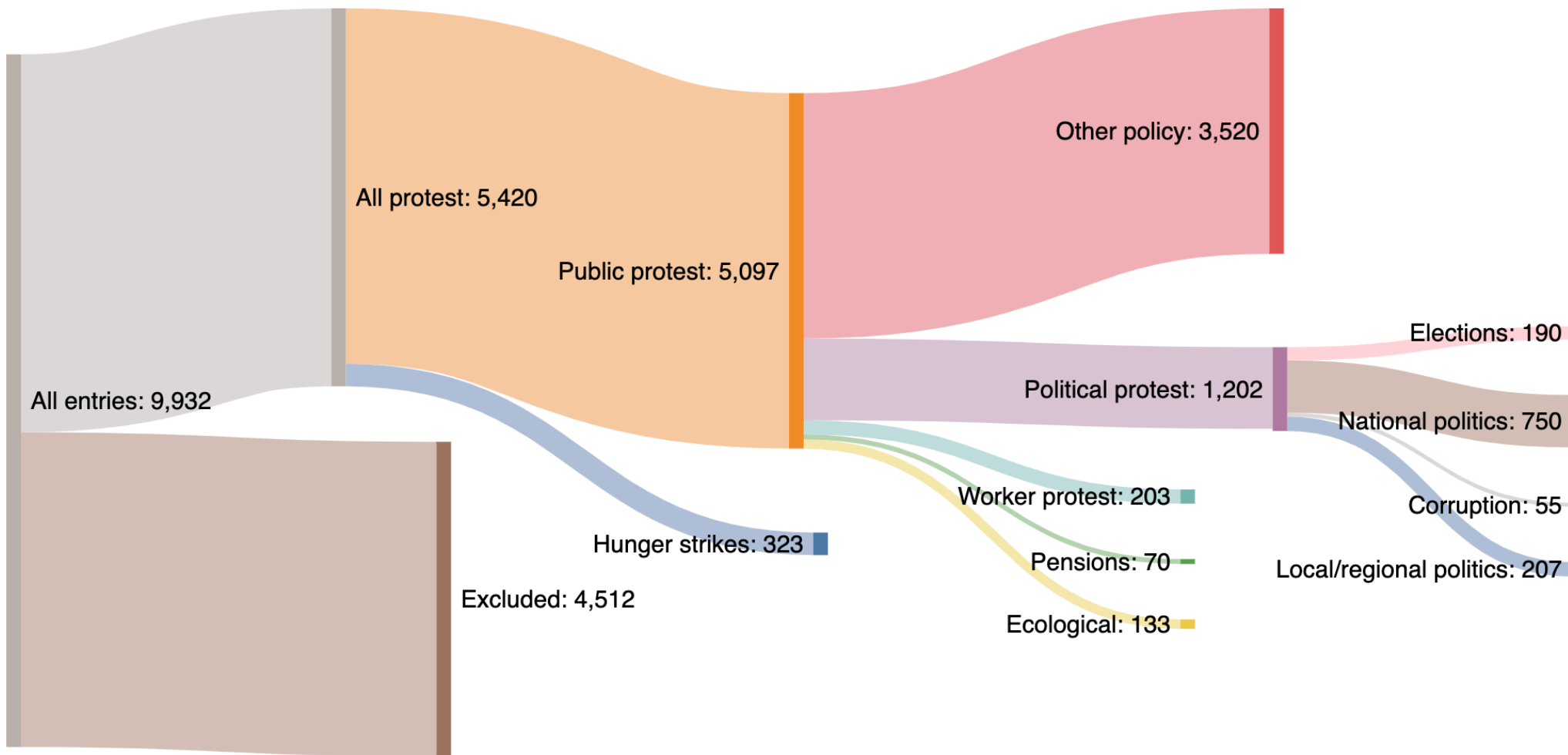
задержаниям, обыскам или нападениям в течение 8 июля подверглись сторонники Навального в 18 городах:

Воронеже, Гатчине, Екатеринбурге, Ижевске, Иркутске, Калининграде,

Краснодаре, Москве, Новороссийске, Казани, Петрозаводске, Барнауле, Бийске

"Over 130 people across Russia detained at Navalny canvassing events" — 09.07.2017.

...according to OVD-Info, participants faced detentions, searches, or attacks on July 8 in 18 cities: ...



Survey data

- Daily/monthly Russian public opinion survey data covering 13 years, 2007–2019
- 82 subnational units
- Unbalanced repeated cross-section of units
- Large, nationally/regionally-representative public opinion surveys
 - Levada Courier
 - VTsIOM Express
 - FOMnibus
- $N_{\text{survey}} = 655,059$
 - Omit rural respondents and Moscow, $N_{\text{survey}} = 334,494$

Estimation strategy

Staggered difference-in-differences

- Linear probability model — OLS with TWFE
- Fixed effects: **region and month**; survey firm; locality size
- SEs clustered at region-week level

Dependent variables (dichotomous)

1. Approval of Putin
2. Approval of governor
3. *“If mass protests take place, will you participate in them?”*

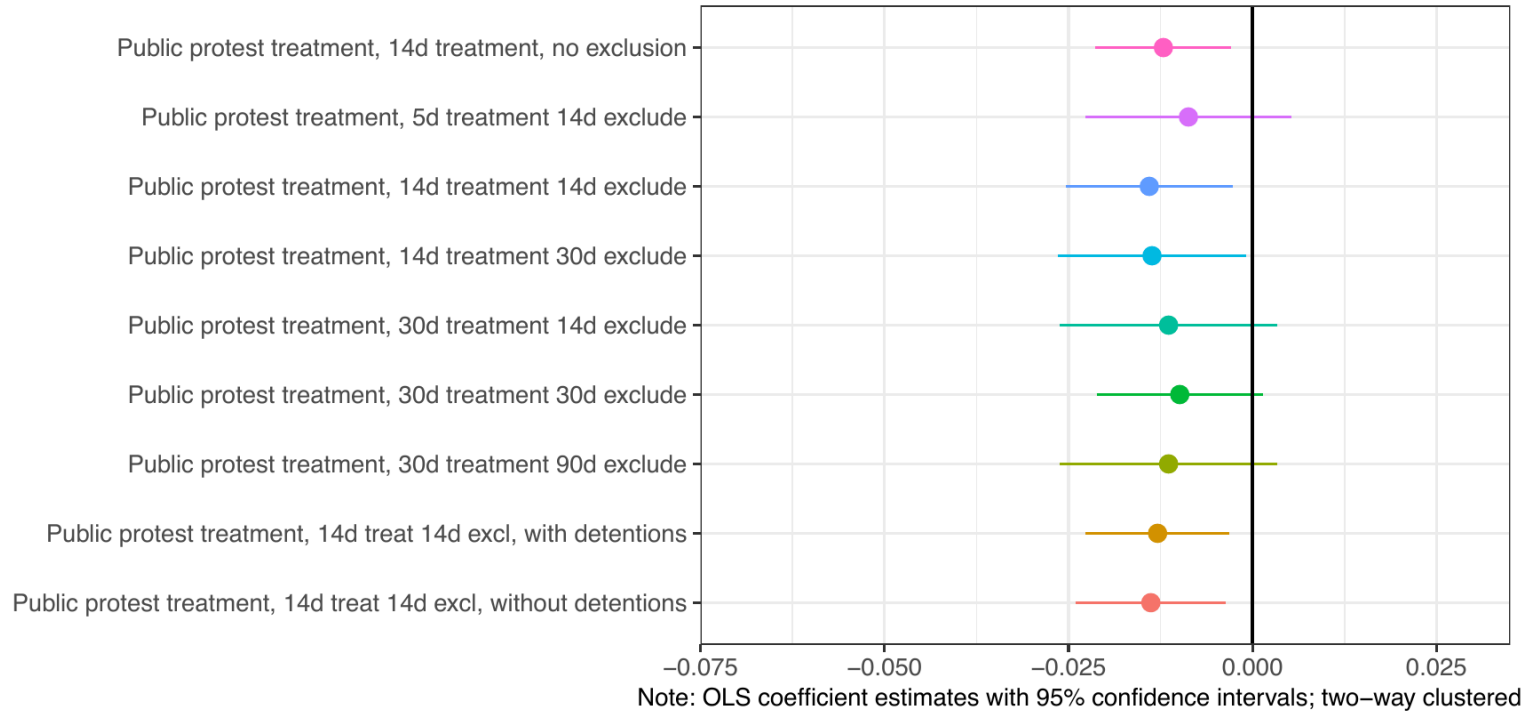
Predictors

- **Predictor of interest:** binary indicator of protest in the region in last 14 days with 14 day exclusion period
- Additional predictors: age, education, gender

Staggered difference-in-differences

- Potential for bias when conducting TWFE estimation of DiD with staggered treatment or heterogeneous treatment effects
 - See: de Chaisemartin and D'Haultfoeuille 2020; Goodman-Bacon 2021; Callaway and Sant'Anna 2021; Sun and Abraham 2021; Wooldridge 2021
- Proposed solutions assume:
 1. Non-nested, unit-level TSCS data structure
 2. Treatment is irreversible
 3. Treated units can be organized into well-defined cohorts
- This project:
 1. Individuals nested within region-months; heterogeneity across individuals
 2. Treatment is a shock with — presumably — temporary effects of unknown longevity
 3. Treatment is in continuous time, no natural cohorts

DV: Putin approval



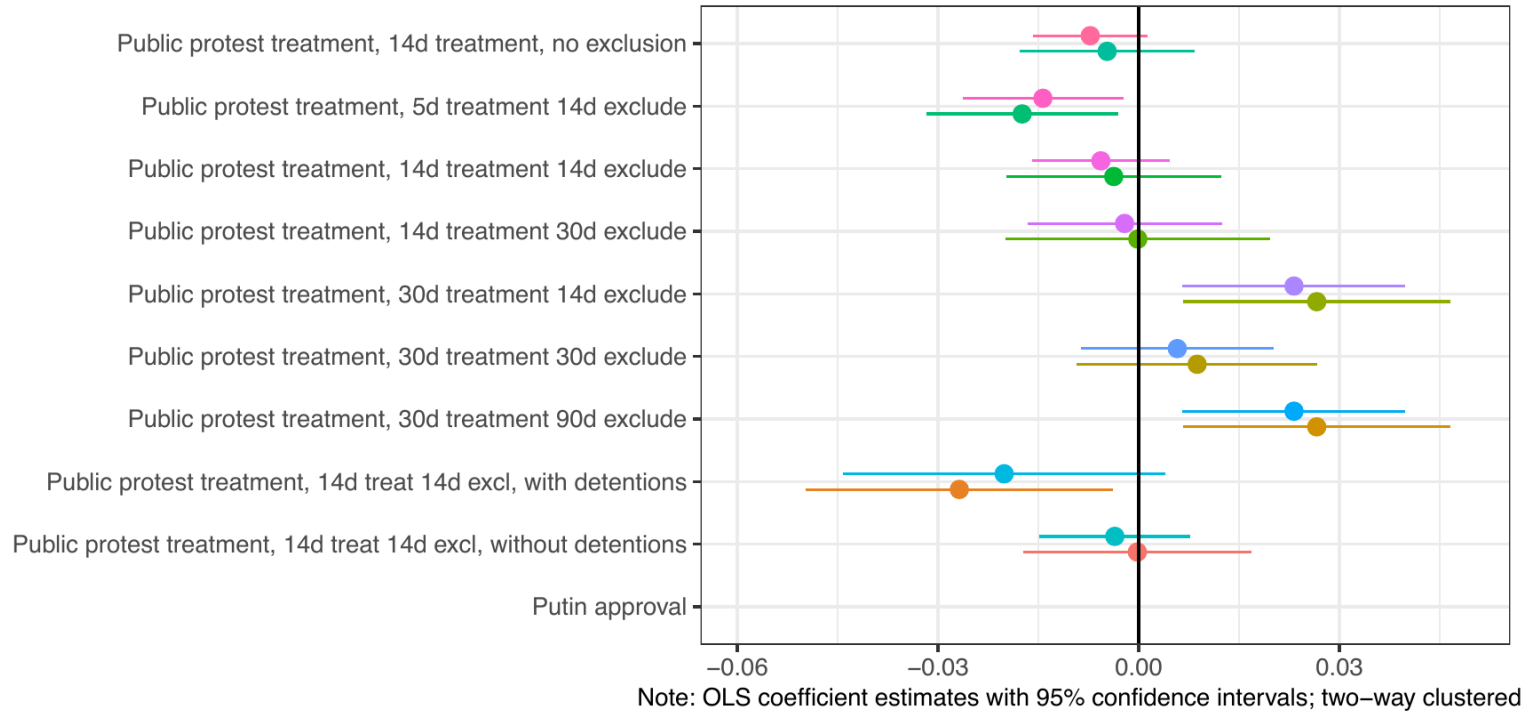
Results: Protest and Putin approval

DV: Putin approval. SEs clustered at region-week.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Protest, 14d, no excl.	-0.012* (0.005)			
Protest, 14d / 14d excl.		-0.014* (0.006)		
Protest, 30d / 30d excl.			-0.010+ (0.006)	
Protest, 14d / 14d, w/ detentions				-0.013* (0.005)
Age	0.000+ (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)
Education	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.003+ (0.002)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.003 (0.002)
Male	-0.067*** (0.005)	-0.066*** (0.005)	-0.066*** (0.005)	-0.067*** (0.005)
Fixed effects (4)	✓	✓	✓	✓
N	270,068	247,002	240,029	270,068
R ²	0.067	0.067	0.067	0.066

+ p<0.1, * p<0.05, ** p<0.01, *** p<0.001

DV: Willingness to protest



Mechanisms: The content of the informational shock

1. Revelation about levels of social discontent

- Protest gives permission to stop falsifying (Buckley, Marquardt, Reuter, and Tertytchnaya 2024)
- ⇒ Acknowledge dislike of **regime/autocrat**

2. Update of priors on probability of repression by the regime

- Newfound 'freedom' to challenge the regime (Frye and Borisova 2019)
- ⇒ Increased **willingness to protest**

3. Learning about regime quality

- Disillusionment, especially among regime supporters
- ⇒ Decreased approval for regime or agents, will depend on **protest demands**

Results: Repression mechanism

14-day treatment, 14-day exclusion. SEs clustered at region-week.

	Would prt	Putin appr	Putin appr	Would prt	Would prt
Protest, no detentions			-0.014** (0.005)		-0.004 (0.006)
Protest, with detentions		-0.013* (0.005)		-0.020+ (0.012)	
Protest, any	-0.006 (0.005)				
Age	-0.001*** (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.001*** (0.000)	-0.001*** (0.000)
Education	-0.006** (0.002)	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.006** (0.002)	-0.006** (0.002)
Male	0.038*** (0.004)	-0.067*** (0.005)	-0.066*** (0.005)	0.038*** (0.003)	0.038*** (0.004)
Fixed effects (4)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
N	173,759	270,068	247,697	192,494	174,073
R ²	0.039	0.066	0.067	0.038	0.039

+ p<0.1, * p<0.05, ** p<0.01, *** p<0.001

Results: Regime quality mechanism

14-day treatment, 14-day exclusion. SEs clustered at region-week.

	Govr appr	Putin appr	Govr appr	Putin appr
National-issue protest			0.002 (0.022)	-0.004 (0.008)
Local-issue protest	-0.056 ⁺ (0.028)	0.001 (0.012)		
Age	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 ⁺ (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Education	-0.006^{**} (0.002)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.006^{**} (0.002)	-0.003 ⁺ (0.002)
Male	-0.050^{***} (0.004)	-0.067^{***} (0.005)	-0.050^{***} (0.004)	-0.066^{***} (0.005)
Fixed effects (4)	✓	✓	✓	✓
N	126,250	267,305	123,475	261,774
R ²	0.046	0.067	0.046	0.067

⁺ p<0.1, ^{*} p<0.05, ^{**} p<0.01, ^{***} p<0.001

Discussion

- Good evidence that public protest depresses approval of Putin by 1.5pp
- Weaker evidence that protest depresses approval of governors by up to 3pp
- Inconclusive/suggestive evidence that protest can raise willingness to protest by almost 3pp
- Weak evidence for a social revelation mechanism
- Good evidence for a repression mechanism
- Mixed evidence for a regime quality information mechanism

Conclusions

- Seeing protest produces the potential for more dissatisfaction and unrest
- Autocrats are right to monitor protest sentiment closely
- Mechanisms: revelation of information about a) levels of discontent in society, b) regime quality, and c) a newfound ability to protest unpunished

Future work

- How long do effects last? Event study approach
- Media coverage
- Future improvements: finer geographic granularity

Thank you

Noah Buckley · Trinity College Dublin

noah.buckley@tcd.ie · noahbuckley.github.io

Questions?